

Ultimate Tic-Tac-Toe Rules

A complete, verbose rules reference with recommended house rules, examples, variants, and beginner strategy notes.

Ultimate tic-tac-toe is a larger, more strategic version of normal tic-tac-toe. Instead of playing on one 3-by-3 board, you play on nine smaller tic-tac-toe boards arranged inside one big 3-by-3 board. The goal is not merely to win small boards. The goal is to win the large board by winning three small boards in a row, column, or diagonal.

Table of Contents

Table of Contents	2
1. The Board	5
2. Players	5
3. Objective of the Game	5
4. How Small Boards Are Won	5
5. The Most Important Rule: Your Move Sends Your Opponent Somewhere	6
6. First Move	6
7. Turn Structure	6
8. Example Turn Sequence	6
9. You Do Not Choose Any Board Freely Most of the Time	6
10. The Free Move Rule	7
11. Can You Play Inside a Board That Has Already Been Won?	7
Version A: Closed-Board Rule	7
Version B: Continue-Playing Rule	7
Recommended Rule	7
12. What Happens When a Small Board Is Drawn?	7
13. Winning the Large Board	7
14. A Small Board Win Happens Immediately	8
15. What If a Move Wins a Small Board and Sends the Opponent to That Same Board?	8
16. Legal Moves	8
17. Illegal Move Handling	8
18. Draws on the Large Board	8
19. Optional Scoring Variant for Drawn Small Boards	9
20. Recommended Complete Ruleset	9
Setup	9

Players	9
First Move	9
Sending Rule	9
Normal Turn	9
Free Move	9
Winning a Small Board	9
Closing a Small Board	9
Winning the Game	10
Large-Board Draw	10
21. Example of a Full Mini Sequence	10
22. Strategic Meaning of the Sending Rule	10
23. Important Tactical Rule: Do Not Send Your Opponent to a Board They Can Win	10
24. Important Tactical Rule: Forcing Moves	10
25. Important Tactical Rule: Winning a Small Board Is Not Always Worth It	10
26. Important Tactical Rule: Center Board Is Usually Valuable	11
27. Board Priority on the Large Board	11
28. Threats on the Large Board	11
29. Forks	11
30. Keeping Track of the Game	11
31. Common Notation	12
32. Variant: Small Board Draw Counts for Player With More Marks	12
33. Variant: Drawn Small Board Counts for Both Players	12
34. Variant: Free Move Anywhere Including Won Boards	12
35. Variant: Must Play in a Won Board If It Has Empty Spaces	12
36. Variant: Simultaneous Large-Board Win Cases	12
37. Teaching Summary	13
38. Compact Rules Card	13

39. Common Beginner Mistakes 13

 Mistake 1: Playing Anywhere 13

 Mistake 2: Forgetting Where the Next Player Goes 13

 Mistake 3: Thinking Only About the Current Small Board 13

 Mistake 4: Not Marking Won Small Boards Clearly 13

 Mistake 5: Forgetting Free Moves 13

40. Practical House Rules to Agree on Before Playing 14

41. Recommended Final Version 14

1. The Board

Ultimate tic-tac-toe uses a board made of nine mini tic-tac-toe boards. Visually, it is a large 3-by-3 grid:

A1	A2	A3
B1	B2	B3
C1	C2	C3

Each of those nine regions is itself a normal tic-tac-toe board:

1	2	3
4	5	6
7	8	9

So the full game has 9 small boards times 9 spaces each, for 81 total spaces.

2. Players

There are two players: Player X and Player O. As in regular tic-tac-toe, players take turns placing their symbol into empty spaces. Usually X goes first, but players may agree beforehand that O goes first, or decide randomly.

3. Objective of the Game

The objective is to win the large board. To win the large board, a player must win three small boards in a row, column, or diagonal.

Example large-board win for X:

X	X	X

The large board is won using the same patterns as regular tic-tac-toe: top row, middle row, bottom row, left column, middle column, right column, top-left to bottom-right diagonal, or top-right to bottom-left diagonal.

4. How Small Boards Are Won

Each small board works like a regular tic-tac-toe board. A player wins a small board by placing three of their marks in a row, column, or diagonal within that board.

X	X	X
O		O

In this example, X wins that small board because X has the entire top row. Once a player wins a small board, that small board is usually considered claimed by that player. You can mark the whole small board as belonging to that player on the large board.

5. The Most Important Rule: Your Move Sends Your Opponent Somewhere

When you play in a space inside a small board, the position of that space determines which small board your opponent must play in next. The square you choose inside your current mini-board sends your opponent to the corresponding mini-board on the large board.

Example: if you play in the top-right square of a small board, your opponent must play their next move in the top-right small board of the large board. If you play in the center square, your opponent must play in the center small board.

Move inside a small board	Opponent must play in
Top-left square	Top-left small board
Top-middle square	Top-middle small board
Top-right square	Top-right small board
Middle-left square	Middle-left small board
Center square	Center small board
Middle-right square	Middle-right small board
Bottom-left square	Bottom-left small board
Bottom-middle square	Bottom-middle small board
Bottom-right square	Bottom-right small board

6. First Move

The first player may usually play anywhere on the entire board. Because there is no previous move, there is no required small board yet. On the first turn, X may choose any empty square in any of the nine small boards. After X moves, the square X chose sends O to the corresponding small board.

7. Turn Structure

A normal turn works like this: the active player looks at which small board they are required to play in, places their mark in any empty square within that required small board, and the square they choose determines which small board their opponent must play in next.

If that move completes three-in-a-row in the small board, the active player wins that small board. If that small-board win creates three claimed small boards in a row on the large board, the active player wins the game. Otherwise, play passes to the opponent.

8. Example Turn Sequence

Suppose X starts by playing in the center square of the top-left small board. Because X chose the center square, O must now play in the center small board.

Then O plays in the bottom-right square of the center small board. Because O chose the bottom-right square, X must now play in the bottom-right small board.

Then X plays in the top-middle square of the bottom-right small board. Because X chose the top-middle square, O must now play in the top-middle small board. The game continues this way.

9. You Do Not Choose Any Board Freely Most of the Time

In ordinary tic-tac-toe, you can place your mark anywhere empty. In ultimate tic-tac-toe, you usually cannot. Most turns are constrained by the previous move. If your opponent played in the bottom-left square, you must play somewhere in the bottom-left small board. You can choose which empty square inside that small board, but you cannot choose a different small board unless a special exception applies.

10. The Free Move Rule

If you are sent to a small board that is already unavailable, you get a free move. A small board is usually unavailable if it has already been won by X, won by O, filled completely, or drawn.

Common rule: if the target small board is already won or full, the player may play in any open small board. This is called a free choice, free move, or wild move.

Example: suppose O plays in the top-left square. Normally, X would have to play in the top-left small board. But if the top-left small board has already been won or filled, then X cannot play there, so X gets to choose any legal empty square in any still-playable small board.

11. Can You Play Inside a Board That Has Already Been Won?

Version A: Closed-Board Rule

Under this rule, once a small board is won, nobody may play in it anymore. The board is closed. This is probably the most common casual version. If a small board is won, no more marks are placed in it. If a player is sent to that board, they get a free move elsewhere.

Version B: Continue-Playing Rule

Under this rule, players may still place marks in a small board even after it has been won, as long as empty spaces remain. The small board is still claimed by the player who won it first, but it can continue receiving moves. Later lines do not usually change ownership. This version creates different strategy and can reduce free moves, but it is less common in simple casual play because it is more fiddly to track.

Recommended Rule

For most games, use the closed-board rule: once a small board is won or drawn, it is closed. No more marks may be played in it. If you are sent to a closed board, you may move anywhere in an open board.

12. What Happens When a Small Board Is Drawn?

A small board is drawn when all nine spaces are filled and neither player has made three in a row within that small board. A drawn small board is usually considered closed. No player owns it. It does not count as X or O on the large board.

Drawn small board example:

```
X | O | X
---+---+---
X | O | O
---+---+---
O | X | X
```

On the large board, that board might be marked as D, -, #, or left neutral, depending on how you are tracking the game.

13. Winning the Large Board

The large board is won when one player claims three small boards in a row, column, or diagonal.

Large board ownership:

```
X | X | X
---+---+---
O |   | O
---+---+---
|   |
```

X wins because X owns the top row of small boards.

Another example:

```
O | X | X
---+---+---
| O | X
---+---+---
|   | O
```

O wins because O owns the diagonal from top-left to bottom-right.

14. A Small Board Win Happens Immediately

When a player completes three in a row inside a small board, they win that small board immediately. The board is claimed at the moment the winning move is made. After that, check whether the large board has been won.

The order is: player makes a move, check whether they won the small board, mark that board as theirs if they did, check whether they won the large board, and if not, determine where the next player must play.

15. What If a Move Wins a Small Board and Sends the Opponent to That Same Board?

This can happen. If your move sends your opponent to a board that your move just closed, your opponent gets a free move under the recommended closed-board rule.

For example, if X plays in the center square of the center board and that move wins the center board, the center square would normally send O to the center board. But because the center board is now closed, O gets a free move.

16. Legal Moves

A move is legal if the space is empty, the space is inside the required small board unless the player has a free move, the small board is still open if using the closed-board rule, and the game has not already ended.

A move is illegal if the space is already occupied, the player plays in the wrong small board, the player plays inside a closed small board, or the player moves after the large board has already been won.

17. Illegal Move Handling

Before playing, players should agree how illegal moves are handled. Common casual handling is to undo the illegal move immediately and let the player make a legal move.

A stricter rule is that an illegal move forfeits the turn. Tournament-style handling usually reverses the illegal move if possible, and if the game state cannot be repaired, the player who made the illegal move may forfeit. For friendly games, the best rule is: fix the mistake immediately and continue.

18. Draws on the Large Board

The entire game can end in a draw. This usually happens if all small boards are won or drawn and neither player has three claimed small boards in a row.

Large board ownership:

```
X | O | X
---+---+---
O | X | O
---+---+---
O | X | O
```

In this example, neither player has a full row, column, or diagonal, so the game is a draw.

19. Optional Scoring Variant for Drawn Small Boards

Some players dislike neutral drawn small boards because they can make the large board harder to finish. The cleanest version is: if a small board is drawn, it counts for neither player.

Other variants exist: a drawn small board counts for both players, a drawn small board counts for the player with more marks in it, or a drawn small board becomes a blocker that prevents either player from completing that line. The recommended version is that a drawn small board counts for neither player, because it avoids weird cases where both players might appear to complete a line using the same drawn board.

20. Recommended Complete Ruleset

Setup

Draw a large 3-by-3 tic-tac-toe board. Inside each square of the large board, draw a smaller 3-by-3 tic-tac-toe board. There should be 81 playable spaces total.

Players

One player is X. One player is O. X goes first.

First Move

X may play in any empty space on the entire board.

Sending Rule

The position of the square a player chooses determines which small board the next player must play in. Playing in the top-left square sends the opponent to the top-left board. Playing in the center square sends the opponent to the center board. Playing in the bottom-right square sends the opponent to the bottom-right board, and so on.

Normal Turn

On your turn, you must play in the small board that corresponds to your opponent's previous move. You may choose any empty space inside that small board.

Free Move

If you are sent to a small board that has already been won, drawn, or filled, you may play in any empty space in any open small board.

Winning a Small Board

You win a small board by getting three of your marks in a row, column, or diagonal inside that board.

Closing a Small Board

Once a small board is won, drawn, or filled, it is closed. No more moves may be played in that small board.

Winning the Game

You win the game by winning three small boards in a row, column, or diagonal on the large board.

Large-Board Draw

If all small boards are closed and neither player has won three small boards in a row, column, or diagonal, the game is a draw.

21. Example of a Full Mini Sequence

Imagine the large board has boards labeled A1, A2, A3 on the top row, B1, B2, B3 on the middle row, and C1, C2, C3 on the bottom row. Each small board has positions 1 through 9.

Move 1: X plays in A1, position 5. Because X played position 5, O must play in B2, the center board.

Move 2: O plays in B2, position 9. Because O played position 9, X must play in C3, the bottom-right board.

Move 3: X plays in C3, position 1. Because X played position 1, O must play in A1, the top-left board.

Move 4: O plays in A1, position 3. Because O played position 3, X must play in A3, the top-right board. The game continues this way.

22. Strategic Meaning of the Sending Rule

The sending rule means every move has two effects: it helps you in the small board where you are playing, and it controls where your opponent must play next.

A move can therefore be good locally but bad globally. You might place a mark that helps you almost win a small board, but if that move sends your opponent to a board where they can immediately win, it may be a terrible move. Ultimate tic-tac-toe is largely about balancing local tactics, global strategy, move control, and threat prevention.

23. Important Tactical Rule: Do Not Send Your Opponent to a Board They Can Win

A common beginner mistake is thinking only about the current small board. Before moving, ask: where will this move send my opponent, what can they do there, can they win that board, and can they win the whole game if I send them there?

For example, if the top-right small board has O O empty in the top row, sending O to that board may let O win the board immediately. Even if your current move looks good, it may be bad if it sends your opponent to an immediate win.

24. Important Tactical Rule: Forcing Moves

Sometimes you can force your opponent into bad choices. You might play a move that sends your opponent to a board where they have only one safe move. Then their forced move may send you somewhere useful.

A forcing chain might look like this: I move here to send you there. You are forced to block there. Your block sends me to a board where I can win. This is one of the reasons ultimate tic-tac-toe is much deeper than normal tic-tac-toe.

25. Important Tactical Rule: Winning a Small Board Is Not Always Worth It

In regular tic-tac-toe, winning is always the whole point. In ultimate tic-tac-toe, winning a small board is good, but the move you use to win it may send your opponent somewhere dangerous.

For example, you may be able to win a small board by playing the bottom-right square. But the bottom-right square sends your opponent to the bottom-right small board. If your opponent is about to win that bottom-right small board, your winning move may be bad. Sometimes it is better to delay winning a small board if the winning move sends the opponent to a dangerous location.

26. Important Tactical Rule: Center Board Is Usually Valuable

The center small board is often strategically powerful because it contributes to many large-board winning lines. On a normal 3-by-3 board, the center square belongs to four possible winning lines, corners belong to three, and edges belong to two.

The same idea applies to the large board. The center small board can help complete the middle row, middle column, and both diagonals. It is valuable, but not automatically decisive; the sending rule can make other boards more urgent.

27. Board Priority on the Large Board

On the large board, the most valuable boards are usually center board first, corner boards second, and edge boards third. The center board is part of four lines, corners are part of three lines, and edges are part of two lines.

Board priority changes depending on what has already happened. If X already owns the top-left and top-middle boards, then the top-right board becomes extremely important because X can win the large board by claiming it.

28. Threats on the Large Board

A large-board threat occurs when a player has two small boards in a line and needs one more to win the game.

Example threat:

```
X | X |  
---+---+---  
O |   |  
---+---+---  
   | O |
```

X threatens to win the game by claiming the top-right board. In that case, O should avoid sending X to the top-right board if X has a chance to win it, and may need to fight for that board directly.

29. Forks

A fork is a situation where one player creates two threats at the same time. In ultimate tic-tac-toe, forks can happen inside a small board, on the large board, or through the sending rule.

A large-board fork is especially dangerous. For example, X might own the center board and two corners, creating multiple possible winning lines. The opponent may not be able to block every future path.

30. Keeping Track of the Game

Because the board has 81 spaces, it helps to mark small-board ownership clearly. When someone wins a small board, you can draw a large X or O lightly over the entire small board, shade the board, write X or O in the corner, circle the board's border, or use a separate large-board tracker.

Large board tracker:

```
A1 | A2 | A3
```

```

-----+-----
B1 | B2 | B3
-----+-----
C1 | C2 | C3

```

When X wins A1, mark A1 as X on the tracker. This keeps the global state clear.

31. Common Notation

You can describe a move by naming the small board and the square inside that small board. For example, A1-5 means top-left small board, center square.

Using board labels A1 through C3 and square labels 1 through 9, B2-9 means center small board, bottom-right square. That move sends the next player to C3, the bottom-right small board.

32. Variant: Small Board Draw Counts for Player With More Marks

Some people use this scoring variant: if a small board fills without a three-in-a-row, the player with more marks in that board wins it. Because X and O alternate, and a full board has nine marks, one player will have five marks and the other will have four. Usually, the player with five marks would claim the board.

This variant makes it less likely for the large game to draw. However, it changes the feel of the game, because small-board control becomes less about tic-tac-toe wins and more about majority control. Use it only if both players agree beforehand.

33. Variant: Drawn Small Board Counts for Both Players

Another variant says a drawn small board counts as both X and O for purposes of the large board. This can produce unusual cases, because both players may appear to benefit from the same drawn boards.

This raises awkward questions: can both players win at once, who wins if a draw board completes both lines, and does the current player win immediately? Because of that, this rule is not recommended unless you define tie-breaking clearly.

34. Variant: Free Move Anywhere Including Won Boards

Some versions allow a free move to be placed in any empty space, even inside a small board that has already been won. This only makes sense if you use the continue-playing rule. Won boards may still accept moves, and a player sent to a full board may move anywhere with an empty space.

For casual play, the cleaner version is that free moves may only go in open, unclaimed, unfinished boards.

35. Variant: Must Play in a Won Board If It Has Empty Spaces

Some rules say that if you are sent to a won board that still has empty spaces, you must still play there. This is part of the continue-playing style. A won board is not closed, a full board is unavailable, and a won but not-full board is still playable.

This reduces free moves, but it also means players may spend moves in boards that no longer matter directly. It is less clean for beginners.

36. Variant: Simultaneous Large-Board Win Cases

Rarely, a move might produce a situation where both players appear to have a winning line on the large board, usually because of unusual draw-board rules.

In the recommended ruleset, this should not happen because only the active player can win a small board on their move, drawn boards count for neither player, and won boards do not change ownership. If you use variants where drawn boards count for both players or board ownership can change, you need a tie-break rule. A reasonable tie-break rule is that the player who made the move that caused the game-ending condition wins.

37. Teaching Summary

To teach the game quickly, say this:

It is tic-tac-toe made of nine tic-tac-toe boards.

Win small boards to claim squares on the big board.

Win three small boards in a row to win the whole game.

The twist is that wherever you move inside a small board determines which small board your opponent must play in next.

If you send them to a board that is already won or full, they may play anywhere.

38. Compact Rules Card

ULTIMATE TIC-TAC-TOE RULES

1. The game board is a 3x3 grid of smaller 3x3 tic-tac-toe boards.
2. X goes first.
3. The first player may move anywhere.
4. After that, each move sends the opponent to a specific small board.
5. The square you choose inside your small board determines the small board your opponent must play in next.
6. On your turn, you must play in the small board you were sent to.
7. If you are sent to a board that is already won, drawn, or full, you may play in any open board.
8. You win a small board by getting three in a row inside that board.
9. Once a small board is won or drawn, it is closed.
10. You win the whole game by winning three small boards in a row on the large board.
11. If all small boards are closed and nobody has three small boards in a row, the game is a draw.

39. Common Beginner Mistakes

Mistake 1: Playing Anywhere

New players often forget that they must play in the board they were sent to. Correction: always look at the previous move. The previous move's square tells you where to play.

Mistake 2: Forgetting Where the Next Player Goes

After every move, say where the opponent must go, such as "I send you to the center" or "You're going bottom-right."

Mistake 3: Thinking Only About the Current Small Board

A move may help you locally but hurt you globally. Before moving, ask where the move sends your opponent, whether they can win that board, and whether they can win the game from there.

Mistake 4: Not Marking Won Small Boards Clearly

When a board is won, immediately mark it as X or O on the large board.

Mistake 5: Forgetting Free Moves

If a player is sent to a closed board, they do not lose their turn. They get a free move.

40. Practical House Rules to Agree on Before Playing

Before starting, agree on these points: Does X always go first? Are won small boards closed? What happens when a small board is drawn? Can players play inside already-won boards? What happens after an illegal move? How are large-board draws handled?

For most players, use these answers: X goes first. Won boards are closed. Drawn boards are closed and count for neither player. You cannot play inside closed boards. Illegal moves are undone if noticed quickly. The game is a draw if no one wins the large board.

41. Recommended Final Version

X goes first.

The first move can be anywhere.

After every move, the square chosen sends the opponent to the corresponding small board.

You must play in the board you are sent to unless that board is closed.

A board is closed if it has been won or drawn.

You win a small board by getting three in a row inside it.

You win the game by winning three small boards in a row on the large board.

Drawn small boards count for neither player.

If sent to a closed board, you may play in any open board.

If all boards close without a large-board winner, the game is a draw.

This is the cleanest default version unless you specifically want a more complex variant.